

Taxi, where one has to park a taxi among kite-fliers and cross railway tracks busy with local trains, or Gully Cricket would become so popular. On any given day, gamers from 209 countries log on to games2win. Kejriwal started the company last year with a venture capital of \$5 million (Rs 22 crore). Last month, he was offered \$100 million (Rs 436 crore) for his website by a US gaming company. "I definitely believe Indian-themed games are the games of the future," he says.

There are many reasons why Indian-themed games are the new buzzword among the gaming companies. For one, the Indian gaming market is a goldmine waiting to be tapped. Unlike the US, where an average gamer is between the ages 28 and 35, Indian gamers are essentially teenagers who have discovered the addictive world of gaming comparatively recently. Whether at home with friends or through multi-player games in cyber cafes, a whole new generation of gamers has emerged and is looking for new experiences, having exhausted the current menu of games with western characters. The Bollywood connection is to ensure that they get hooked. FX Labs has just launched its first PC game, Agni—Queen of Darkness, where a superheroine saves her child from evil forces. The game has Malaika Arora in a Lara-Croftian role, and the lady has been endorsing the game as the real-life Agni inspiration. Ghajini, of course, will be picked up because the protagonist in the game is an animated version of Aamir. Similarly, Kahani World is collaborating with Virgin Comics to develop the content for the animation film,

Secrets of the Seven Sounds, written by filmmaker Shekhar Kapur and Gotham Chopra, produced by Deepak Chopra which stars Pravin Dabas, Koel Purie and Gaurav Kapoor.

Global gamers already have a taste of India, thanks to Coderman, the latest cyber-gaming super-

hero. Sure, he's based in the Silicon Valley, but he's no Clark Kent or Peter Parker. Our Coderman is Mani Subramaniam by day, living the American dream as a techie with his perfect family of two children, Rajiv and Maya. He dons a cape and tights to solve complex computer-related crimes with his coding prowess. "Let's face it. Even if you made Barbie wear a sari, she will still be a blonde with blue eyes," says Biren Ghose, CEO and president of Bangalore-based Kahani World, which has designed the Coderman game. Every country in the world now knows the Indian coder with an "unpronounceable" name.

The problem with most Indian-themed PC games is that they are de-

signed with the Indian gamer as a primary target and right now, it's a pretty small market. Unlike in the US, a game, priced at a few hundred rupees and above here, doesn't even sell 20,000 copies. Even hugely popular worldwide games such as Pac Man or Space Invaders managed to sell only a few hundred copies in India. Rajesh Rao, CEO of Dhruva Interactive, one of India's oldest gaming companies, says he is extremely wary of an Indian-themed game and is preparing to launch a casual gaming website, gametantra.com which will have universal themes. But others are a lot more hopeful. The most popular flash game on the FX Labs website is Crazy Idly, a game where one turns waiter and has to balance wobbly idlis till they reach the customer's table. Ghose says one of his games, Raju, the Autorickshaw,

was designed with Indian and Thai gamers in mind, but the game found a world-wide appeal. The Hyderabad Auto and Bombay Taxi games, similarly, have seen immense popularity.

Since last year, NASSCOM, India's parent body for all things related to information technology, has started an animation and gaming forum that is working closely with the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting to make gaming more accessible in India. Ghose, who is chairman of the forum, says India's biggest hurdle to gaming is that there isn't enough computer penetration in the country and most people play from cyber cafes, so can't be dedicated gamers. But now that Bollywood has discovered gaming, or the other way around, that could change the rule of the, well...game. ■



A game based on the Kargil war (above); Malaika Arora as the Indian Lara Croft; the Bachchan game

